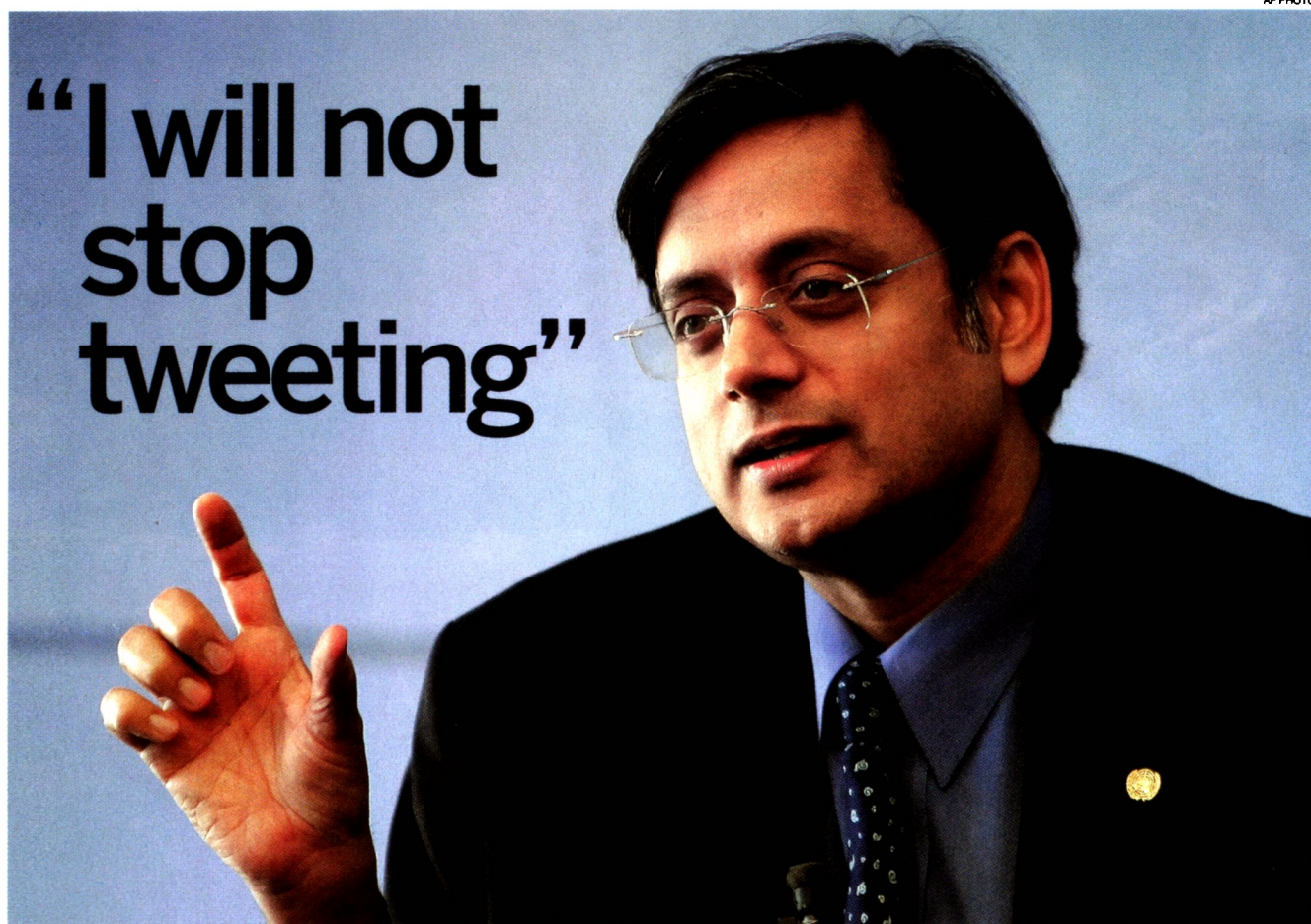




**“I will not
stop
tweeting”**

What started off as a pleasant diversion from hard-edged politics soon turned into an embarrassing downpour as Minister of State Shashi Tharoor found himself engulfed in quick-fire controversies. First for putting up in a five-star hotel for three months, then for his ‘cattle class’ remark. In an exclusive interview to Senior Editor SAURABH SHUKLA, the undiplomatic diplomat tries to set the record straight.

Q. Were you disappointed that your party spokespersons rebuked you? Did you ever feel that it was not worth it being a minister?

A. Of course, I was disappointed as I had came here to make a difference. But at the cost of being blunt, I’ll have to say that I have made a serious finan-

cial sacrifice. I left a well-paying corporate job, gave up my speaking fees, which were generous, and I can’t write books anymore. Secondly, it has been an emotional sacrifice, I am far away from my wife. But when I got this opportunity to serve my country, I thought let me see if I can make a difference. I don’t even get six hours of sleep; I work for more than 18 hours.

Q. But have you made up with the Congress leadership and has the controversy been buried?

A. The prime minister has spoken on this and that puts to rest everything else. I have understood that I am in public life now. In politics, what matters is not what we intend to say but what people understand and what you call as perception. As the famous Shakespearean phrase goes, “The

success of a jest doesn’t lie in the tongue of the teller but in the ear of the listener”, and that holds true.

Q. But some in your party believe that your tweets caused the problem and you should stop tweeting now.

A. I will not stop tweeting. It is an innovative medium of communication. Barack Obama uses it, Hillary Clinton used it while she was in Delhi and Australian Prime Minister Kevin Rudd does it. So, Twitter will continue and I will not exercise self-censorship but some moderation.

Q. You handle the Gulf and Africa portfolio in the Ministry of External Affairs but for two years you were lobbying the governments in these countries for commercial contracts. Isn’t that a conflict of interest?

A. Afras is a Dubai-based Indian company. I remained the chairman of Afras until the day I became a minister because in India MPs are allowed to have business interests.

“I asked the MEA about the payment of my hotel bills. They told me I was entitled to nothing.”